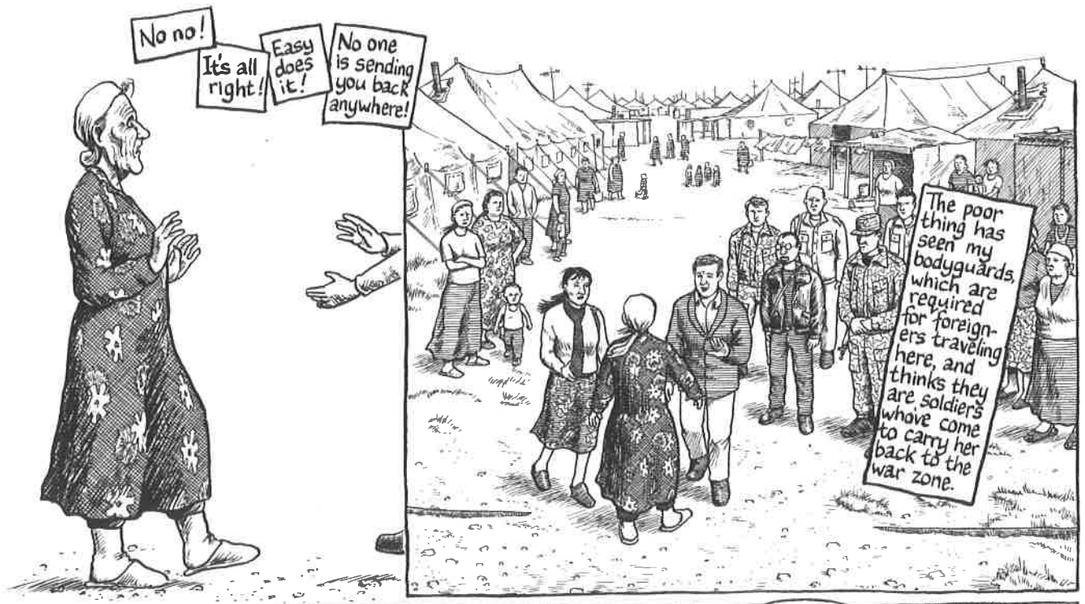
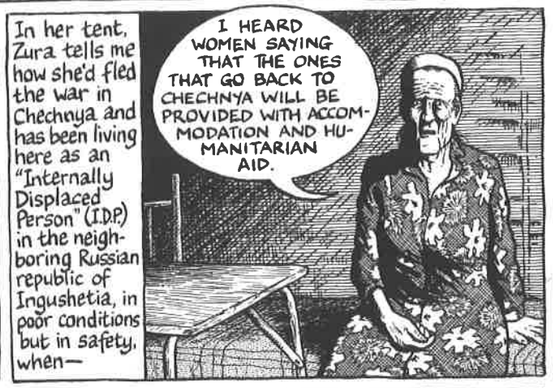
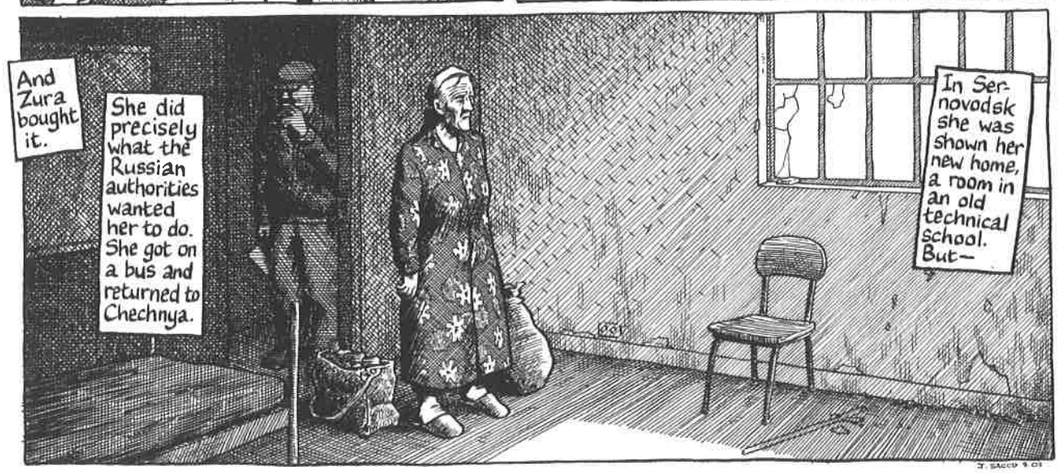
CHECHEN WAR, CHECHEN WOMEN

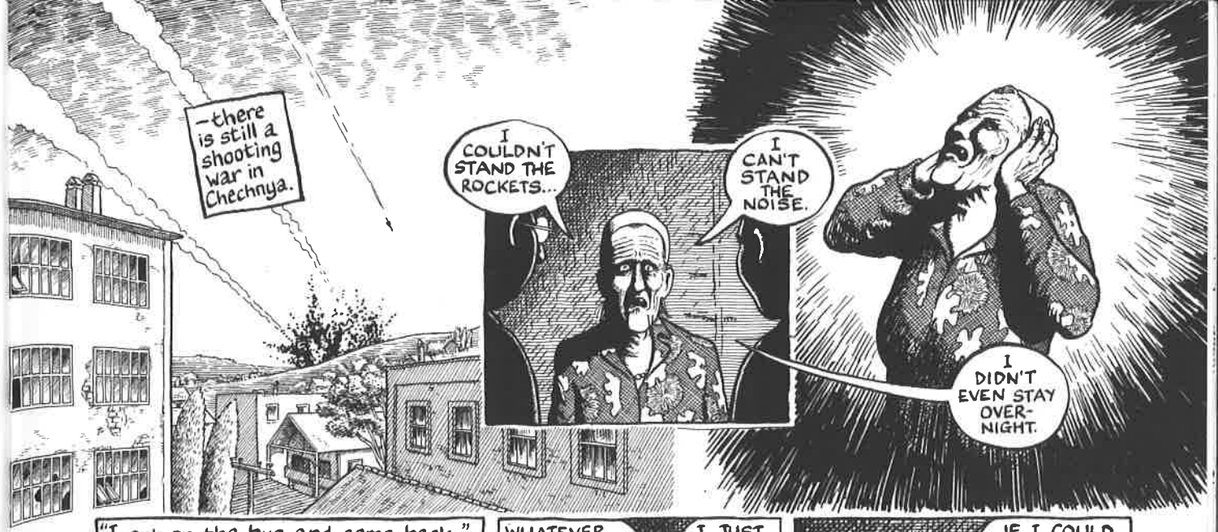
I. GOING HOME

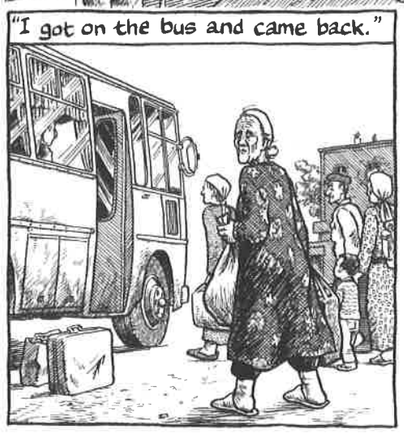

No no!
It's all right!
Easy does it!
No one is sending you back anywhere!
The poor thing has seen my bodyguards, which are required for foreigners traveling here, and thinks they are soldiers who've come to carry her back to the war zone.

Okay!
Everything is under control!
Her name is Zura, and she gets it now.
My translator has explained I come in peace.

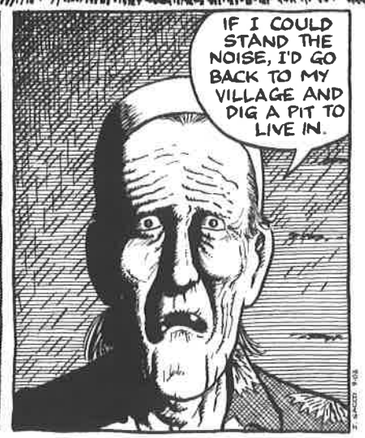

In her tent, Zura tells me how she'd fled the war in Chechnya and has been living here as an "Internally Displaced Person" (I.D.P.) in the neighboring Russian republic of Ingushetia, in poor conditions but in safety, when—
I HEARD WOMEN SAYING THAT THE ONES THAT GO BACK TO CHECHNYA WILL BE PROVIDED WITH ACCOMMODATION AND HUMANITARIAN AID.

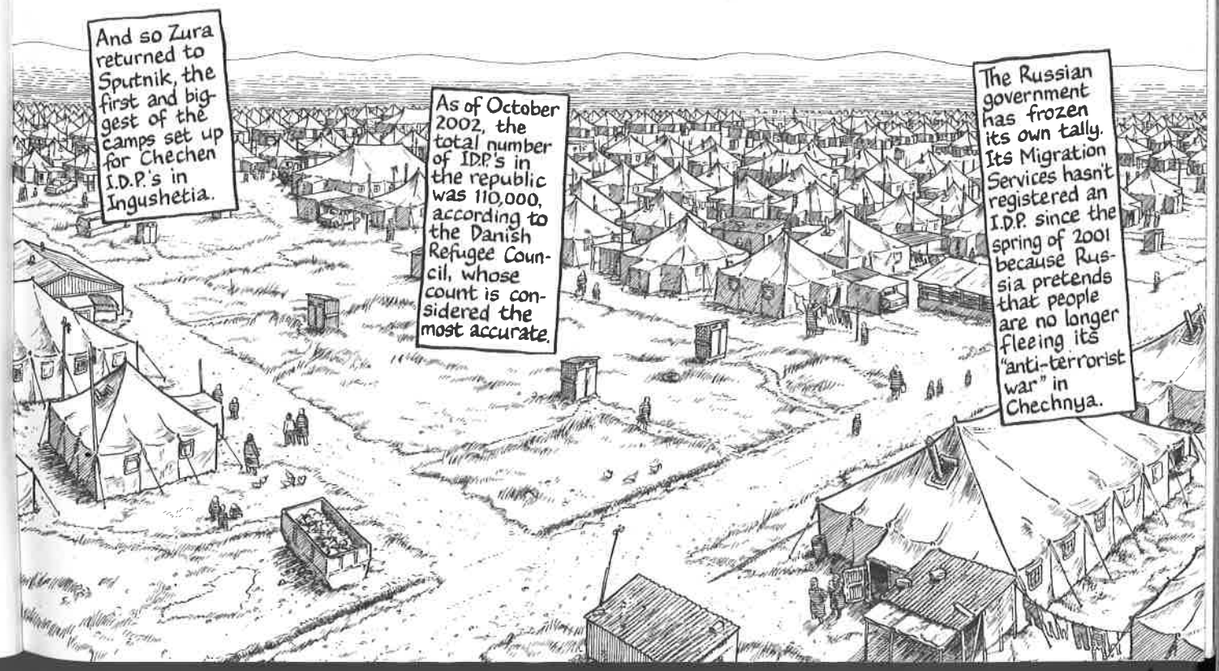

And Zura bought it.
She did precisely what the Russian authorities wanted her to do. She got on a bus and returned to Chechnya.
In Sernovodsk she was shown her new home, a room in an old technical school. But—


—there is still a shooting war in Chechnya.
I COULDN'T STAND THE ROCKETS...
I CAN'T STAND THE NOISE.
I DIDN'T EVEN STAY OVERNIGHT.

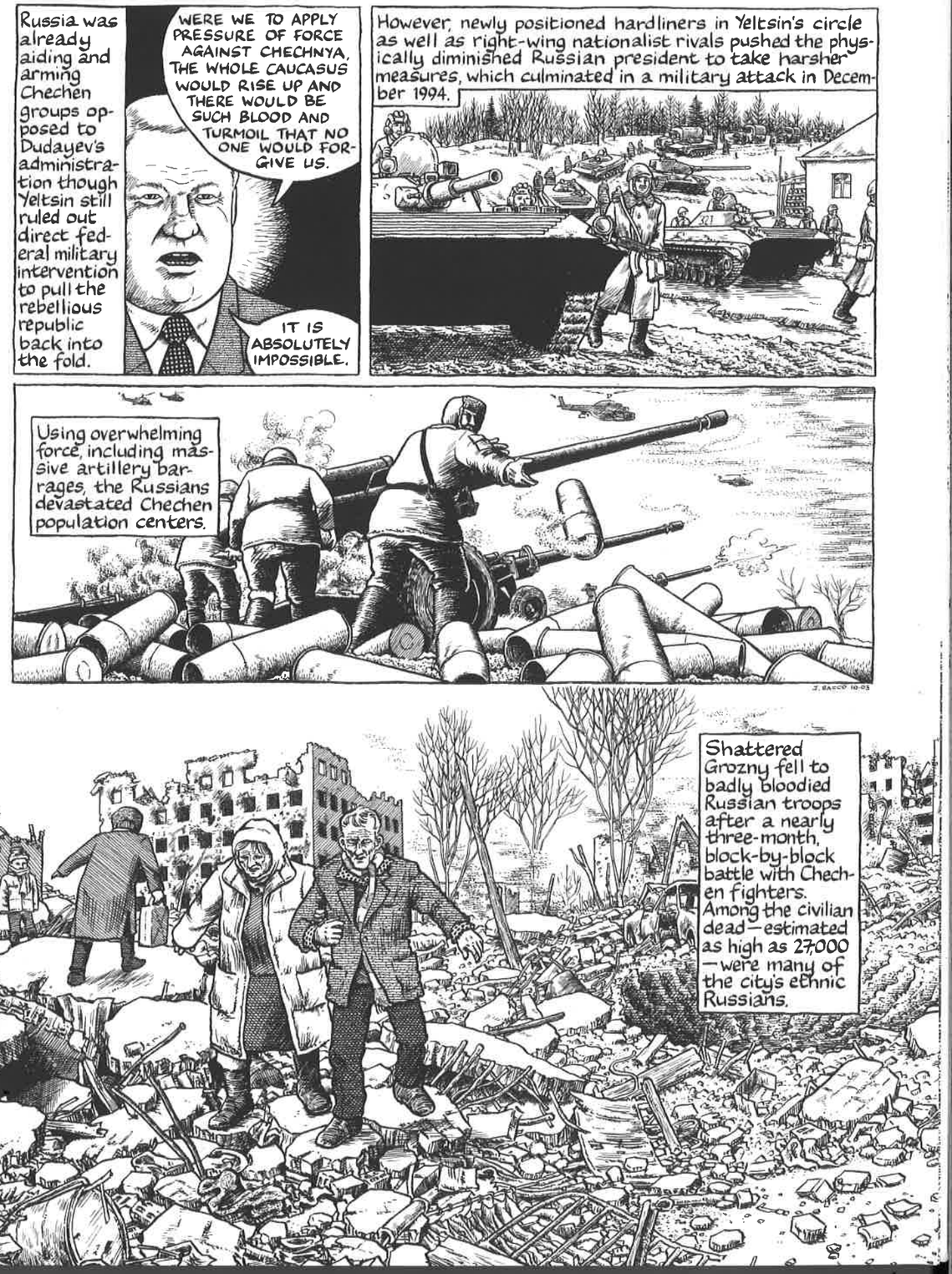

"I got on the bus and came back."

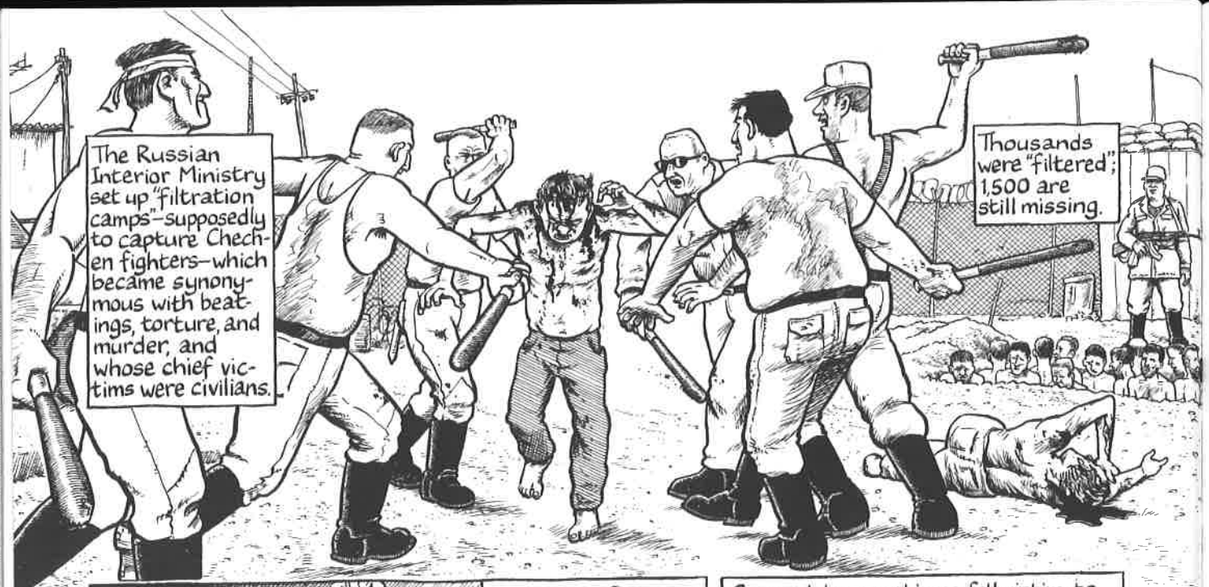
WHATEVER THEY PROMISE THE I.D.P.'S IN CHECHNYA, IT DOESN'T MATTER.
I JUST CAN'T BEAR THE NOISE.

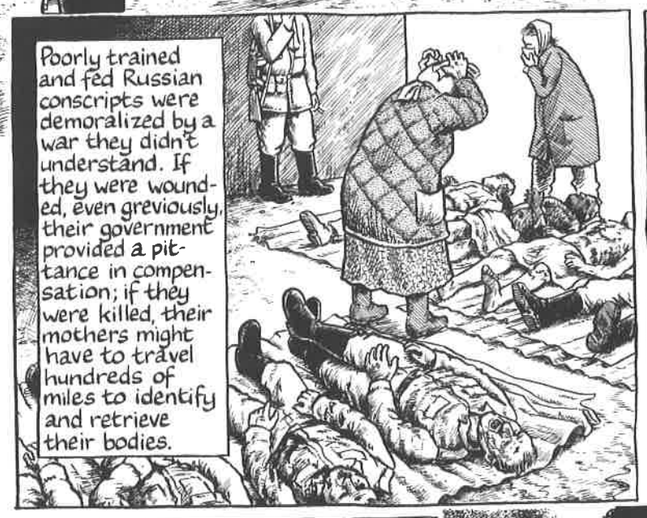

IF I COULD STAND THE NOISE, I'D GO BACK TO MY VILLAGE AND DIG A PIT TO LIVE IN.

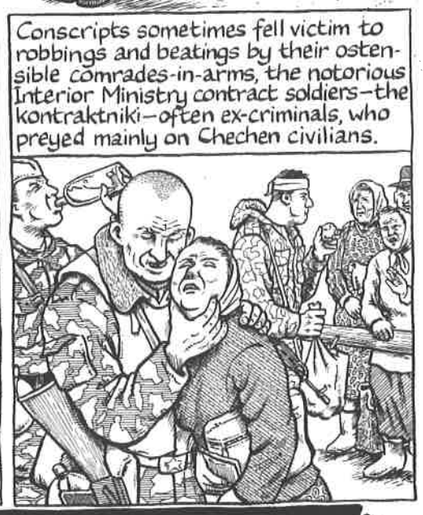

And so Zura returned to Sputnik, the first and biggest of the camps set up for Chechen I.D.P.'s in Ingushetia.
As of October 2002, the total number of I.D.P.'s in the republic was 110,000, according to the Danish Refugee Council, whose count is considered the most accurate.
The Russian government has frozen its own tally. Its Migration Services hasn't registered an I.D.P. since the spring of 2001 because Russia pretends that people are no longer fleeing its "anti-terrorist war" in Chechnya.

Chechnya's most recent anguish began in the early 1990's as the Soviet Union collapsed. The deep grievances of the Chechens against Moscow found radical expression in the person of Jokhar Dudayev, a former loyal Soviet general, who declared Chechnya's independence first thing after ascending to the presidency of the republic in 1991.
Chechnya, which is located in the North Caucasus, had a population of about 1.2 million, one quarter of whom were ethnic Russians. The Russians, who had enjoyed special privileges under the Soviets, made up the majority of the population of the capital Grozny.
Moscow
RUSSIAN FEDERATION
UKRAINE
CHECHNYA
TURKEY
SYRIA
IRAQ
IRAN
Certainly the Russians, but also many Chechens, did not want a total break with the Federation.
RUSSIAN FEDERATION
Caspian Sea
INGUSHETIA
Grozny
Nazran
CHECHNYA
DAGHESTAN
GEORGIA
0
50
MILES
Dudayev steered Chechnya—whose independence was never recognized by any country—out of Moscow's political sphere. Civic life deteriorated and poverty was widespread. Government workers went without their salaries.
The kidnap and ransom business, which had historical roots in Chechnya, reasserted itself.
Corrupt Chechens and Russian politicians took advantage of the lack of regulations, customs-free borders, and general chaos to enrich themselves.
Meanwhile, the disputes between Dudayev's supporters and his internal opposition turned deadly.
Dudayev had already dissolved Chechnya's parliament and constitutional court.
As Russia's media stoked long-held prejudices against the Chechens, the political will of Boris Yeltsin's government to negotiate with the problematic Dudayev ebbed.
Under increasing Russian threat, Chechens rallied to Dudayev.
J. SACCO 10-03


Russia was already aiding and arming Chechen groups opposed to Dudayev's administration though Yeltsin still ruled out direct federal military intervention to pull the rebellious republic back into the fold.
WERE WE TO APPLY PRESSURE OF FORCE AGAINST CHECHNYA, THE WHOLE CAUCASUS WOULD RISE UP AND THERE WOULD BE SUCH BLOOD AND TURMOIL THAT NO ONE WOULD FORGIVE US.
IT IS ABSOLUTELY IMPOSSIBLE.
However, newly positioned hardliners in Yeltsin's circle as well as right-wing nationalist rivals pushed the physically diminished Russian president to take harsher measures, which culminated in a military attack in December 1994.
Using overwhelming force, including massive artillery barrages, the Russians devastated Chechen population centers.
J. SACCO 10-03
Shattered Grozny fell to badly bloodied Russian troops after a nearly three-month, block-by-block battle with Chechen fighters. Among the civilian dead—estimated as high as 27,000—were many of the city's ethnic Russians.

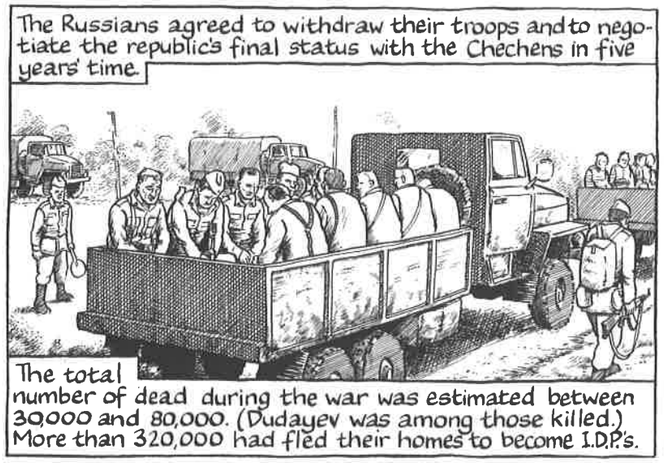

The Russian Interior Ministry set up "filtration camps"–supposedly to capture Chechen fighters–which became synonymous with beatings, torture, and murder, and whose chief victims were civilians.
Thousands were "filtered"; 1,500 are still missing.

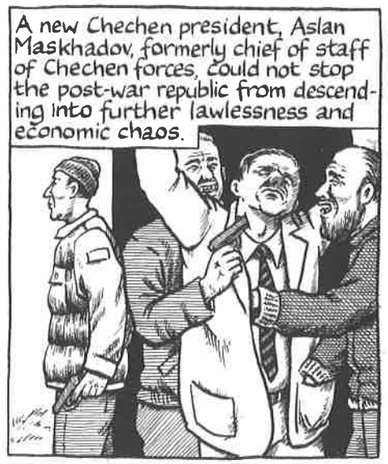

Poorly trained and fed Russian conscripts were demoralized by a war they didn't understand. If they were wounded, even greviously, their government provided a pittance in compensation; if they were killed, their mothers might have to travel hundreds of miles to identify and retrieve their bodies.

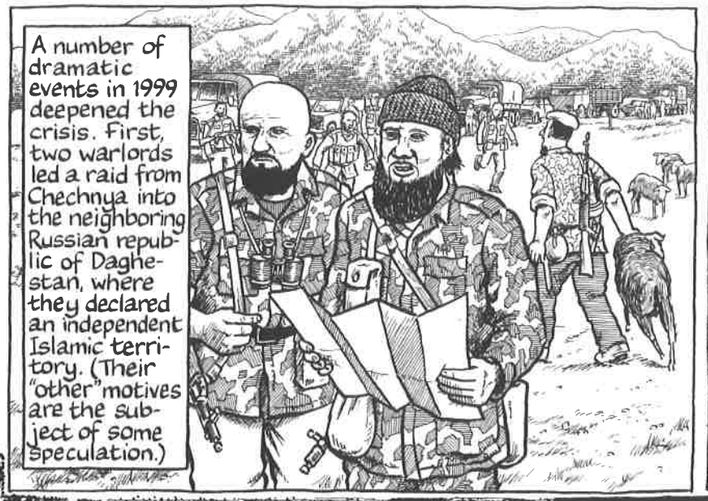

Conscripts sometimes fell victim to robbings and beatings by their ostensible comrades-in-arms, the notorious Interior Ministry contract soldiers–the kontraktniki–often ex-criminals, who preyed mainly on Chechen civilians.

The state of the Russian armed forces was a prescription for robbery, rape, and murder in the areas "liberated" from the "terrorists."

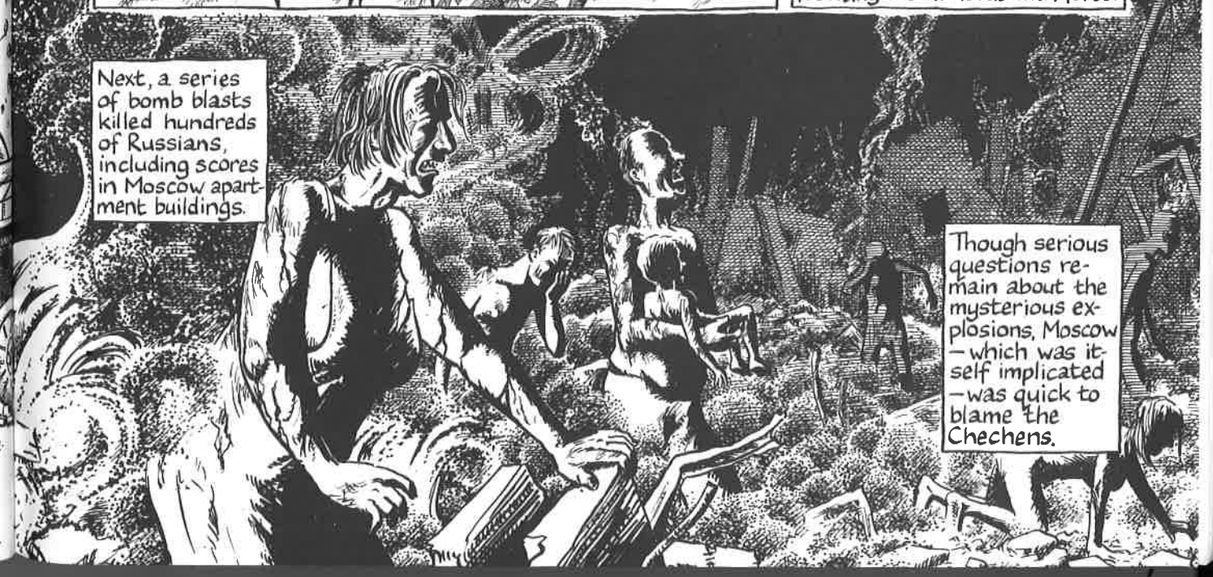
In August 1996, in a surprise offensive, Chechen separatists recaptured Grozny, dealing the Russians a stunning defeat.


The Russians agreed to withdraw their troops and to negotiate the republic's final status with the Chechens in five years' time.
The total number of dead during the war was estimated between 30,000 and 80,000. (Dudayev was among those killed.) More than 320,000 had fled their homes to become I.D.P.'s.


A new Chechen president, Aslan Maskhadov, formerly chief of staff of Chechen forces, could not stop the post-war republic from descending into further lawlessness and economic chaos.


A number of dramatic events in 1999 deepened the crisis. First, two warlords led a raid from Chechnya into the neighboring Russian republic of Daghestan, where they declared an independent Islamic territory. (Their "other" motives are the subject of some speculation.)

The raid precipitated the reemergence of the Moscow hawks. Yeltsin picked Vladimir Putin, the counterintelligence chief, to be Russia's prime minister.
Putin lost little time in confronting the warlords with force.


Next, a series of bomb blasts killed hundreds of Russians, including scores in Moscow apartment buildings.
Though serious questions remain about the mysterious explosions, Moscow–which was itself implicated–was quick to blame the Chechens.

With popular backing, Putin launched a second war on Chechnya in 1999. Federal forces took Grozny again after severe bombardments and house-to-house fighting and with seeming disregard for civilian losses.

Russian troops have managed to occupy most of Chechnya thereafter, but the separatists still operate and exact a toll.

Large bombs —including suicide bombs —have brought death not just to Russian soldiers and their local supporters, but also to innocent bystanders in places like Grozny's markets.

Those who remain in Chechnya must also contend with the danger of landmines, the imposition of curfews, and the certainty of power and water cuts.

And into this chaos, Russia pretends that it is perfectly safe for people like Zura to return and start their lives again.

J. SACCO 11-03

Or that it is safe for Raisa, who fled to Ingushetia after her husband was killed, and must now raise five children alone...

THIS BOY IS ONLY EIGHT YEARS OLD AND HE HAS HEART PROBLEMS.

HE FALLS UNCONSCIOUS WHEN HE SEES RUSSIAN SOLDIERS.

THE RUSSIANS COME AND TURN EVERYTHING UPSIDE-DOWN, AND THEY INSULT AND ABUSE PEOPLE.

THEY SHOUT AT WOMEN AND CHILDREN.

THEY TAKE EVERYTHING THEY WANT FROM THE HOUSES.

TV.'S, CARPETS, CLOTHES.

IN ONE DAY THEY CAME FIVE TIMES.

THEY CAME MAYBE 40 TIMES ALL TOGETHER.

Or that it is safe for Zalva, who accompanies her sons daily through the many Russian checkpoints on the way to Grozny, where they study, and then back to Ingushetia, where they've taken refuge.

JUST LAST WEEK A RUSSIAN SOLDIER GRABBED THE SLEEVE OF MY 16 YEAR OLD AND WANTED TO TAKE HIM OUT OF THE CAR.

HE WET HIMSELF.

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But despite all the stories that filter in from Chechnya, despite what they know themselves, some I.D.P.'s still try to go back. Some feel their conditions in Ingushetia are too miserable to endure any longer.

Back in Sputnik camp, I meet Larisa and her sister Fatima, who tells me—

MY TENT WAS IN TERRIBLE CONDITIONS, ESPECIALLY WHEN IT RAINED.

I COULDN'T GET A NEW TENT.

SO WHEN EVERYONE PUT IN AN APPLICATION [FOR CHECHNYA], I PUT MINE IN.

EMERCOM, the Russian agency responsible for emergencies and natural disasters, promised her "a room with all the conveniences," and was so pleased when she agreed to move back that it sent a small truck to take her and her kids to Gudarmes, Chechnya.

The small room she was given was clean, she says, but came without gas or heat or a functioning sink. The toilet was outside.

Worse, the humanitarian aid EMERCOM doles out in Chechnya—it has stopped doing so in Ingushetia—is a tiny fraction of what her family needs.

She says the monthly ration per person is one can of beef, one tin of condensed milk, one kilo of sugar, one kilo of rice, and one packet of tea.

I repeat: per month.

And about that canned beef—

THE QUALITY IS SO BAD WE CAN'T EAT IT.

J. SACCO 12.03

But what is she doing here in Sputnik?

Is she moving back?

I WOULD COME BACK, BUT ANOTHER FAMILY HAS TAKEN OUR PLACE.

IF I WAS GIVEN ANOTHER TENT, I WOULD COME BACK WITH GREAT PLEASURE.

In fact, Fatima is here to pick up a handout from her brother and sister. They give her 1,000 to 1,500 rubles ($30 to $50) a month to make ends meet.

IF THEY HAD TOLD THE TRUTH, WE WOULD HAVE STAYED THOUGH IT'S DIFFICULT HERE.

Her sister Larisa tells me she lives here in a tent holding 36 people, where hanging sheets and blankets are the only partition between families.

WE'RE SO OVERCROWDED HERE THAT PEOPLE RUN INTO EACH OTHER.

Still—

I WANTED TO GO BACK TO CHECHNYA. I'M HAPPY MY HUSBAND HELD ME BACK.

J. SACCO 12.03

WHAT REFUGEES?

by Joe Sacco ©2002

RUSSIA SWEEPS THE CHECHENS UNDER THE RUG

Every so often, with a straight face, Russia's President Putin declares that the fight to keep Chechnya in the Russian Federation is won.

The bloody hostage crisis in a Moscow theater put the lie to that, as do the comments of Zara Ozdiyeva, and others like her, who continue to cross the border from Chechnya into the neighboring Russian republic of Ingushetia...

WE WERE ESCAPING DEATH.

WE LEFT OUR HOME AND EVERYTHING WE HAD THERE...

IN CHECHNYA WE HAD TO SLEEP UNDER THE BEDS BECAUSE OF THE BULLETS AND SHELLS.

My dear Zara! You are spoiling Putin's image as the man who brought order to the North Caucasus!

And so to bring reality in line with fantasy, Putin wants you and the 110,000 other "Internally Displaced Persons" (IDP's) either packed back to Chechnya — where Russia's brutalities against civilians are notorious in its "anti-terrorist war" — or scattered to less visible sites than this eyesore of a tent camp.

No camps means no refugees! No refugees means the situation is under control!

For months the word has filtered down that the clock is ticking for the Chechens who've found sanctuary in Ingushetia.

A 20-step plan signed in May by Ingush and pro-Russian Chechen representatives, under Russia's helpful direction, states plainly that the camps are to be removed and the IDP's sent back to Chechnya.

Haron Elzhurkayev, the commandant of a small refugee settlement in an abandoned chicken farm, describes a heated meeting between camp leaders and a Chechen politician who owed his allegiance to Moscow...

HE TRIED TO THREATEN US SAYING, IF WE THINK THERE WON'T BE "CLEANSING" OPERATIONS HERE, WE ARE WRONG.

And in a tent camp called Iman an IDP named Tamara relates the threat made during a personal visit by Russia's First Deputy Head of Migration Services in September.

THEY SAID THEY WOULD BRING BULLDOZERS AND TRACTORS TO SMASH ALL THE TENTS.

They didn't use force then, but are they about to use it now? Russian troops have surrounded the biggest tent camps in a move residents fear precedes forcible repatriation.

Officially, the Russian position is still that IDP's will only be moved "voluntarily."

But this fellow, Islam, a resident of Iman, isn't buying it. Ask him what "voluntarily" means. Other Chechen IDP's, collaborators with the Russians, carted off his tent while the rest of his family was away. He couldn't resist those goons alone, he says.

THEY SAID THEY WOULD SEND ME TO ANOTHER TENT, BUT THAT TENT WAS REMOVED ALSO.

And in this way the IDP's are encouraged to "voluntarily" go back to Chechnya or move to the abandoned Ingush factories the Russians claim are better than Iman camp. But Islam would rather live in this mud-brick room he's building.

Meanwhile, what is going on at Bart camp? Every day a truck comes and dumps gravel right where the IDP's live. The truck belongs to an Ingush company that leased the land to the Russian authorities to provide space for the spillover of IDP's from Bart. But it seems the Russians haven't been paying the rent, according to Marietta Bokova, the camp's deputy commandant, and the company wants its land back.

In fact, Russia has all but reneged on its obligations to the IDP's. Gas and electricity are sometimes cut off for weeks because Russia will no longer pay the bill, and it has long stopped distributing a ration of soup and bread.

Four hundred people could be displaced here in Bart. But does that matter to Russia?

To hell with Rosa, whose tent is about to be swallowed up by the gravel!

THEY DON'T EVEN TELL THE IDP'S TO GO OUT. THEY JUST DUMP THE GRAVEL.

THEY DON'T EVEN LEAVE SPACE FOR PEOPLE TO WALK.

But don't you get the message, Rosa? There is only one way to walk, and that is back to Chechnya. Help your president, Mr. Putin, declare victory—again!